

never to tire of work. But research shows that most people begin to get bored and dissatisfied with work at about age 40.

A. J. Jaffe, at the Bureau of Applied Social Research of Columbia University, has found that the mid-40s are the watershed of life. At age 40 'upward occupational mobility comes largely to a halt. And therein lies one of the main problems . . . In our society the lack of continued progress is tantamount to failure.'" Not only the 40-year-olds but their employers seem to sense the change at this point. Jaffe found that only a tiny handful of managers get any real pay increases or promotions after age 40.

Horatio Alger stories taught that only the slothful burn out. Hard chargers like Horatio Alger, you, and me could look forward to a life of exciting challenges and sweet fruits of success. But Nancy Mayer, in *The Male Mid-Life Crisis*, puts it succinctly: "Horatio Alger lied."

In the old days, those who found out about Horatio's big lie kept right on working. They had to. They needed a paycheck to live. Some lucky few with the money to retire were wise enough to do so. But most people were too set on the American dream, too envious of their neighbors, and too wrapped up in their drive for recognition to admit that something might be wrong.

Today's 40-year-old is better educated, more open to change, and richer. For perhaps the first time in history, millions of American men and women can retire when they want to rather than at "normal" retirement age. Many achievers, including those you read about in this book, retire before age 55. Thousands more are likely to do so in the next few decades.

Retirement isn't the only way to skate through the 40s crisis. But any solution must involve a radical change in beliefs, goals, your view of work, and even your way of life. Otherwise some very predictable things will begin to happen. Those things make trips to the dentist look like life's pleasure peaks.